

After returning to India, he applied for jobs in three places—IIT Kanpur, IIT Madras, and IIT Bombay. The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kanpur became his abode for the next 16-17 transformative years. Prof. Sadagopan says, “I had a great time at IIT Kanpur. Because then, the city did not have much to offer, so, all of our activities were confined within the institute. All faculty members used to stay at the campus.” He used to return home for a cup of evening tea with a newspaper in hand. There was no television in those days so newspapers were the main source of information. Prof. Sadagopan mentions the excellent student-academic relationship at IIT Kanpur. During this period, he got involved in some nation-building projects. The ERNET (Education & Research Network of India) project in 1985-86 stands as a testament to his contributions, reflecting his commitment to advancing the nation’s technological infrastructure.

In an era when the Internet was in its infancy, Prof. Sadagopan’s involvement in the ERNET project was transformative. It was not an easy task to share data and programs. Prof. Sadagopan says, “In the process of building ERNET, the country developed and internalised the technology of the internet. In 1995, when VSNL launched internet across the country, many of the engineers were trained by ERNET project.”

At IIT Kanpur, Prof. Sadagopan got a liberal work environment that allowed him to experiment with education technology. Therefore, he along with other team members continued experimentation with office automation and multimedia teaching content development among other things. During this period the country was also going through several changes, mainly for computer policy and technology adoption. Prof. Sadagopan remembers, “It was the time between 1979 and 1995. The Ministry (at that



Among MIIT students and staff

time it was a department) of Electronics became centre stage and computer policy was introduced. I had been quite involved with all of them. I also started working with the Ministry of Electronics.” During that tenure, he took an active part in the growth of IT company CMC Limited and also got involved in the large-scale project for the computerisation of the railway reservation system.

In 1995, Prof. Sadagopan joined IIM Bangalore as a professor in the QMIS (quantitative methods and information systems) area. The growing emphasis on industry-academia interactions prompted Prof. Sadagopan to establish the ERP Centre with help from SAP and Ramco. He also established the supply chain centre with help from Siemens.

In 1999, Prof. Sadagopan joined IIIT Bangalore as the first director of the institute and spent the next 22 years there. IIITs represent a set of new-generation universities started in India in the late 90s with a special focus on IT. IIIT Bangalore is one of the first such institutes. As the first director of IIIT Bangalore, he was involved in the visioning, planning, and executing the growth of this institute, which is counted as one of the premier institutes in India.

“Before joining IIIT Bangalore as director, I never thought that I would do an administrative job. I am a hardcore nut-bolt kind of engineer. However,

I am an intuition-driven person. I decided to join the IIIT intuitively after receiving an invitation from the Chief Secretary of the State mentioning that the government wanted me to do that.”

Prof. Sadagopan was involved with several large-scale IT initiatives in India, including:

- RTGS from the Reserve Bank of India
- Algo Trading from the National Stock Exchange
- UPI from NPCI
- Core banking in several public sector banks, including the Bank of India, Canara Bank, and the Indian Overseas Bank
- Post Office Bank
- SAP implementation at leading public sector companies, including Indian Oil, BHEL, NTPC, and private sector companies, including Tata Motors, Ashok Leyland, and Maruti Udyog

Large-scale projects that have a global impact include:

- Chairing MOSIP (Modular Open Source Identity Platform) that built an open source version of the Citizen Identity project (like AADHAAR), during 2017-2021; MOSIP is currently being implemented in about a dozen countries
- As the Mentor Director involved in setting up the Myanmar International Institute of Information Technology (MIIT),